



OVERVIEW

Gwent is a competitive card game for 2 players played in two parts. First, the players will draft their deck, creating synergies in and disrupting their opponent's plans. Then, those decks will be used to play a three round match. Whoever manages to win two of those rounds, wins the game.

DIFFERENCES FROM THE VIDEO GAME

Gwent the Drafting Card Game is an unofficial variation of Gwent the Witcher Card Game. It shares many of the rules with it, however there are a few differences.

The major ones are:

- **Card Changes.** Almost every card's power and/or abilities have been adjusted or even completely changed.
- **Draft.** Instead of building the deck before the game, there exists a special Draft Phase that has both players simultaneously construct a deck according to specific rules.
- **Rarity and Provisions.** The provision system is not present. Instead, cards are balanced according to their rarity.
- **Faction Mixing.** The Draft Phase allow the players to add to their deck cards from up to two different factions (not including the Neutrals).
- **Hand Size and Card Draw.** The hand size has been reduced to 8. At the end of every round, the players only draw 2 cards instead of 3.
- **Assimilate Tag.** As it is not possible to Create cards in the physical version, the Assimilate tag now triggers whenever you play a non-Neutral card that is not from your starting faction. This includes the cards that were in your starting deck, but do not come from your faction.
- **Focus Tag.** A new tag, exclusive to the physical version. It functions similarly to the Patience tag from the Video Game, however with a couple differences. It is explained in more detail on page 11.

Needless to say, when playing Gwent the Drafting Card Game, information from this rulebook takes precedence over information from the Video Game.

CARD ANATOMY

A. NAME

The name of a card.

B. TAGS

The type that the unit or special card represents. Some cards may have no tags, while others have multiple. They don't have an inherent effect, but may be referred to by card effects.

C. ABILITY

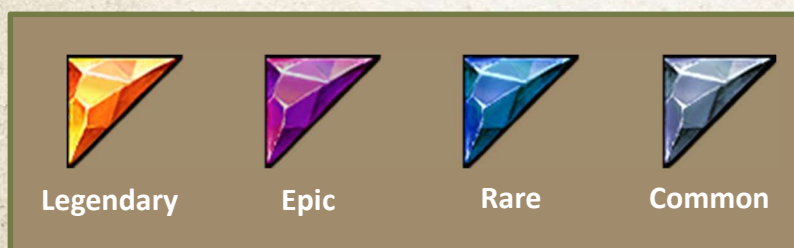
The card text that describes the card's effect.

D. STRENGTH

The power of a card. To win a round, your units must have higher total strength than your opponents. Special cards don't have a strength – they are identifiable by a flame symbol instead.

E. RARITY

The triangle crystal's color shows the rarity of a card. There are four rarities in Gwent:



Cards of higher rarities are usually stronger.

F. FACTION

The faction of the card can be told either by the pattern of the name field or by the symbol in the bottom-right.

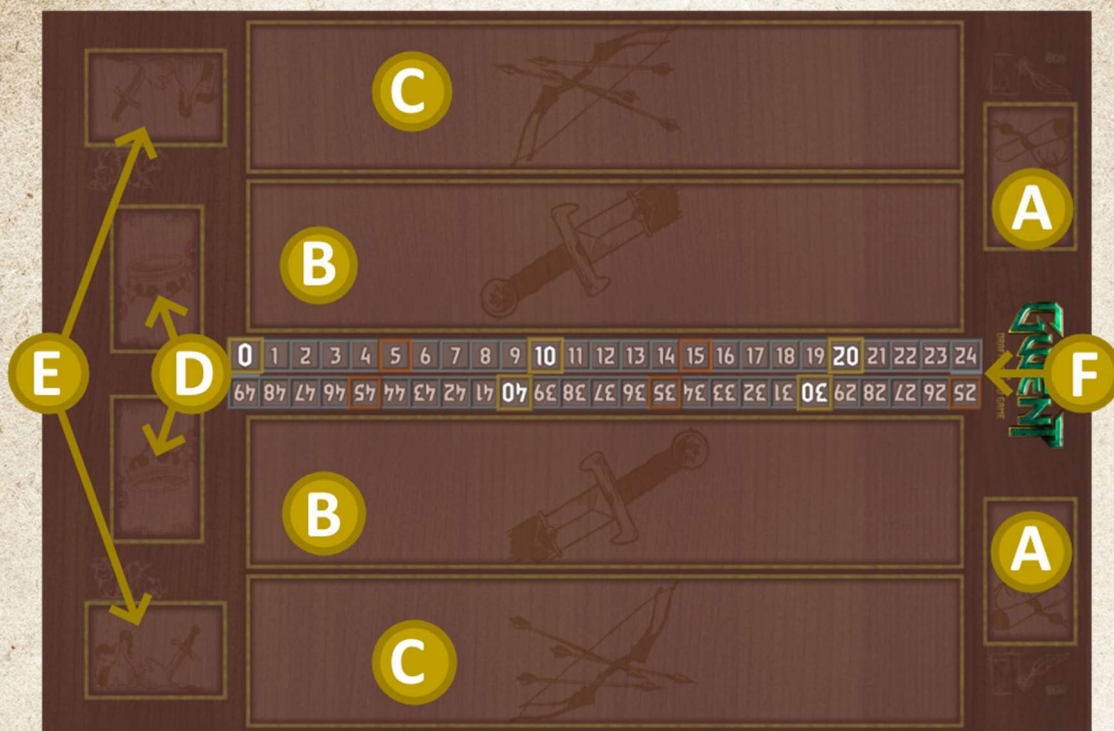


Unit card



Special card

GAME BOARD



A. DECK

The space to put a players deck.

B. MELEE ROW

One of two rows where a player can play their units.

C. RANGED ROW

One of two rows where a player can play their units. The rows together form the Battlefield.

D. LEADER

A space for players leaders.

E. GRAVEYARD

A space to put discarded cards. This is where you put units that died or special cards that have been played. At the end of a round all cards from the battlefield are placed here.

F. POINT TRACK

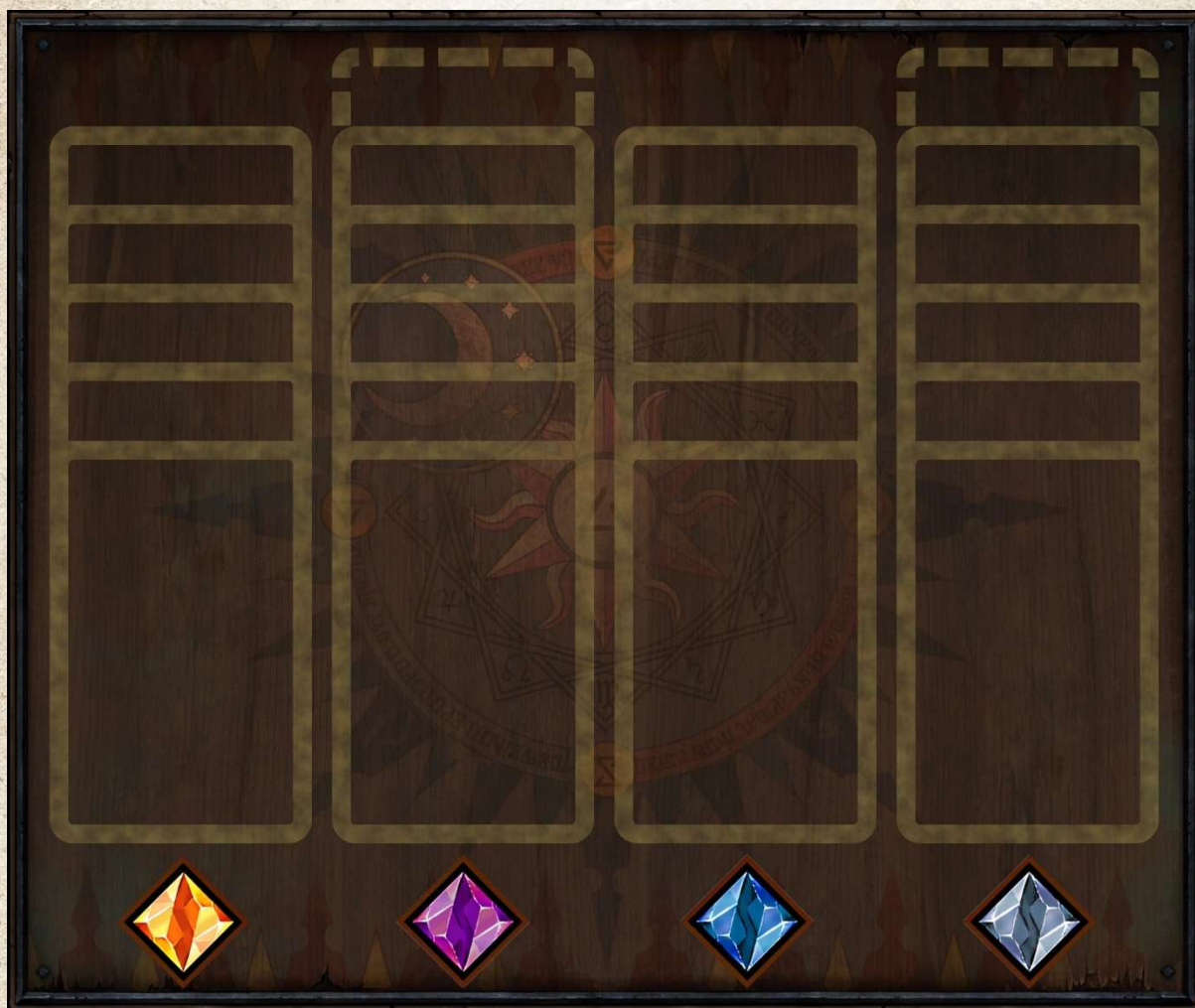
Keeps track of the current points on each players side of the board.

DECK-BUILDING RULES

Every deck drafted in the game must follow a couple rules:

1. A deck must consist of exactly 20 cards.
2. A deck must contain no more than 5 Legendary and no more than 5 Rare cards. There is no limit to the number of Common or Epic cards.

To keep track of these rules, when drafting a deck place the added cards on the special Draft Boards.



Each Draft Board has a column with a number of spaces for cards of each rarity – 5 spaces for the Legendary and Rare cards, and 6+ for the Epic and Common cards.

DRAFT PHASE

Every game of Gwent is started with a draft phase, during which the players will create their deck. This phase will have the players choose a total of 20 cards and a leader ability.

SETUP

1. Place the faction boards on the table.
2. Set aside the Leader cards and the Token cards (identifiable by a different cardback)
3. Divide the cards by the faction and rarity and place them on according spots on the faction boards.

4. Each player must choose their faction – in the base set the available factions are the Northern Realms, Monsters, and Nilfgaard.

DRAFT – BUILDING THE CORE

The first part of the Draft has the players build the core of their deck. It will consist of 8 cards from their faction – 2 Commons, 2 Rares, 2 Epics, and 2 Legendaries – and a Leader. These cards will not be revealed to the opponent before the match starts, so they can be used to surprise them.

Both players draw 3 random Legendary cards from their faction. They choose one, place it face down on their Draft boards in the correct space, and put the other 2 at the bottom of the corresponding deck. Do the same with Epic, Rare, and Common cards.

This process is then repeated, but in the reverse order – start with drafting a Common card, then a Rare, Epic, and a Legendary card. Now each player should have 8 cards selected.

Each player then chooses a Leader from the pool of their faction's Leaders. Unlike the Core Cards, the Leaders are revealed immediately after selection.

DRAFT – SHARED POOL

In the second part of the draft, players will complete their decks by taking cards from a shared pool. Shuffle together all bronze Neutral cards with the unused bronze cards from the two factions being played, forming the Bronze Deck. Repeat the same with the gold cards, creating the Gold Deck. Do not shuffle in any cards from the factions that were not chosen.

Deal 5 cards from the Bronze Deck face up between the players. Flip a coin to determine the starting player.

Players will now take turns until both have complete decks. On your turn you might do one of two actions:

1. ADD A CARD TO THE DECK

Pick one of the face up cards in the middle and add it to your deck. It must follow the deck-building rules (see page 4). Immediately place it on your Draft board in the corresponding place to keep track of your card rarities.

If any player already has drafted at least 15 cards, you must also discard one card from the pool. If possible, it has to be of the same faction as the drafted card.

2. PASS AND DISCARD CARDS

Choose two cards from the pool and discard them. Do not add any cards to your deck this turn. You may never Pass and Discard twice in a row.

IMPORTANT! When passing and discarding, you must always leave at least one card from each faction in the pool, if possible.

After a player's turn, draw cards to replace all that were discarded or added to a deck. A card should always be replaced with one of the same border color.

When any player adds the 12th card to their deck, the pool expands. From now on deal 6 Bronze and 3 Gold cards in the middle.

When any player adds the 15th card to their deck, the pool refreshes quicker. After drafting a card, you must also discard one card from the pool. If possible, it has to be of the same faction as the drafted card.

Once any player adds the 20th card into their deck, their draft is complete. They will not take any more actions in the Draft Phase. Once that happens, the other player may no longer perform the Pass and Discard action.

MATCH PHASE

When both players have completed their decks, the match begins.

SETUP

1. Place the main board in the middle of the table, between the players.
2. Place the leaders selected by the players in the leader spaces. Shuffle the players decks and put them on the deck space.
3. Place Order tokens on the Leader cards – number equal to the Leader's charge count. These represent how many times each Leader can be used.
4. The player that went second in the Draft - Shared Pool phase - becomes the starting player and receives a Stratagem.
5. Each player shuffles their deck and draws 8 cards.
6. **Mulligan phase:** The starting player is allowed up to 3 mulligans. The other player is allowed up to 2 mulligans. They have to perform them now or pass.

A **mulligan** means discarding one card and then drawing one card from the deck. If there are no cards in players deck, they may not perform a mulligan. After the mulligan phase, shuffle the cards discarded through mulligans back into the player decks.

7. Once both players have passed or performed all their allowed mulligans, the first round starts. The starting player takes the first turn.

MATCH STRUCTURE

A match in Gwent is divided into rounds. The player that manages to win two of them, wins the game.

Before each round there is a mulligan phase, where players may redraw some of their cards. While the rounds are scored independently, choosing how much to invest in every particular round is key to winning the game.

PLAYERS TURN

At the start of the player's turn, trigger Weather cards on their side of the battlefield (see XXX).

During a players turn, they may play one card and activate certain cards. These can be done in any order. A player may instead Pass before taking any actions, ending their involvement in the round.

Pass – this means that the player will not take any more actions this round. The opponent will still be able to play if they haven't passed yet. When a player passes, they may not play any cards, use orders or use leader abilities until the end of the current round. However, all cards passive effects remain active.

On their turn, a player **must** play a card from hand. A card may be either played normally (on the battlefield) or into the graveyard.

A player can only play exactly one card from hand during their turn, unless certain effects allow them to do otherwise.

Play a card into the graveyard

Instead of resolving a card's effect, a player can always choose to immediately discard it without executing its effect. The card is then placed in a player's graveyard. This does not trigger any effects on existing cards, including ones that require a card to be played.

This action usually is not beneficial to the player and should only be done in unusual situations.

Play a card on the battlefield

Choose a card from hand and put it on the board.

If it's a special card: immediately resolve its effect and put the card in the graveyard.

If it's a unit: choose a row on your side of the battlefield to put the unit in. All units can be played in any row, however some will benefit from one more than the other. While you can choose where on a row to play a unit, you can not change the placement of existing units.

Example



Initial Card Placement



Good – the new card was played between two existing cards without changing their order.



Good – the new card was played at the end of a row and didn't move other cards.



Wrong – the order of previously played cards has been changed. This is not allowed to happen.

OTHER ACTIONS

Apart from playing a card, a player may take additional actions during their turn. These may be performed any number of times in a turn and can be done both before and after playing a card from hand.

Using an order

Some cards may have an **Order** ability. If such card has an **Order** ready (represented by an order token on the card), a player may discard the token to perform the card's **Order** effect.

Some cards have the **Charges** keyword. They may store multiple order tokens, each representing one use of the **Order** ability. There is no limit to the number of charges that can be used in one turn.

A card's **Order** usually cannot be used on the same turn it is played or summoned, unless it has **Zeal**.

Using the leader

The leaders are special cards that offer additional utility to the player. Every leader has a number of uses, described by their **Charges** keyword. Leaders without the **Charges** keyword are assumed to have one charge.

Some leaders also have passive effects. Those are always active, even if the Leader has no **Charges** left.

If a player's leader has at least one **Charge**, they may use them. Remove one **Charge** from the leader card and execute their effect. This may be done multiple times in a turn, as long as the leader has **Charges** remaining.

Using a stratagem

A stratagem is a special card given to the starting player to compensate for going first. It should be immediately placed in the melee row of their side of the battlefield at the start of Round 1.

Similarly to cards with **Order** abilities, a player may trigger the Stratagems **Order** ability on their turn. When a stratagem is used, remove the card from the game. It is not placed in the graveyard.

If a stratagem is not used by the end of the Round, remove it from the game.

END OF TURN

When you don't want to perform any more actions, your turn ends. Update the point track to reflect the current point sum on both sides of the battlefield.

If any of your cards have an order token on the exhausted side, flip it to the ready side.

If any of your cards have cooldown tokens, remove one. If the last cooldown token has been removed, replace it with a ready order token.



END OF ROUND

When both players pass, the round ends. The player with more points on their side of the battlefield wins the round and gains a victory token. In the event of a tie, both players gain a victory token.

If any player has 2 victory tokens, the game ends and they are declared the winner. It is possible for both players to have 2 victory tokens – the game then ends in a draw.

If neither player won, set up the next round. If the stratagem has not been used, it is removed from the game. All cards from the battlefield are placed in the graveyard. If any had the **Doomed** status, they are removed from the game instead.

Exception: if any unit has the **Resilience** status, it is reset (See page 13), but remains on the battlefield.

Both players draw 2 cards, never to exceed the maximum hand size of 8. Any unused draws get turned into extra mulligans at the beginning of the next round.

PLAYING A CARD

When playing a card, a number of different effects can be triggered. This is the order of their execution:

1. **Deploy effects:** If the card has a Deploy effect, it has to be resolved now.
2. **Cards triggered by the Deploy ability:** Some of the cards already on the battlefield might have an ability that is triggered by the new card's Deploy ability. Resolve their effects now. If multiple cards have triggered, first resolve the ones controlled by the opponent, then the current player. If multiple cards controlled by the same player have been activated, they choose the order in which to resolve them.
3. **Cards triggered a when card is played:** After resolving all the effects and reactions for the Deploy ability, the new card is considered fully played. If that triggered any abilities, they are resolved now in the same order as in step 2.

In the rare case when a triggered activation triggers yet another card, resolve the newly triggered abilities first, before continuing to resolve the triggers of the originally played card.

CARD EFFECTS

Every card has a unique ability written below its name and tags. The ability of a unit is active as soon as the unit is played. The ability of a special card is performed when the special card is played.

BOOSTING AND DAMAGING

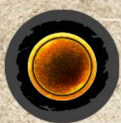
Some effects may boost or damage a card. This increases or decreases the cards power by the specified amount.

If a units power is higher than the one printed on the card (also known as base power), it is **boosted**.

If a units power is lower than its base power, it is **damaged**.

If a units power is reduced to 0 or lower, it is killed. Remove it from the battlefield and put it in the graveyard.

STATUSES



Shield: Absorbs the first instance of damage. Status is removed after.



Poison: Applying poison to an already poisoned unit destroy it.



Lock: Disables the abilities of a card. Has no effect on other statuses.



Veil: The card may not gain any more statuses.



Resilience: Cards will stay on the board at the end of the round.



Defender: The opponent may not target any other cards on this row.



Doomed: When the card leaves the battlefield, it is banished.



Spying: Indicates cards that are on the opponents side of the battlefield.

ARTIFACTS

Artifacts are a card type that has special behaviour. They are identified by the chalice symbol in the top left (instead of a number or a flame symbol).

When an Artifact is played, place it on the Battlefield like you would do with a unit. Just like units, Artifacts will take up space in a row. However, unlike units, Artifacts don't have a power.

Artifacts may not be damaged or boosted. However, they have special abilities that may interact with other cards.

Artifacts may only be targeted if the card text specifically says it can target Artifacts or if it can target any card.

WEATHER

Weather cards are special Artifact cards that symbolize row effects. They have a duration, represented by Counters.

They trigger at the beginning of the allied turn and remove a Counter from self. If a Weather card has not Counters on it, Banish it.

When a card instructs you to Spawn Weather for X turns, Summon the appropriate Weather Token to the specified row and place X Counters on it. If there already is a Weather Token in that row, don't Summon a new one – just add X Counters to the existing one instead.

In the base set the only Weather card available is Frost, however more types may be added in the future.



KEYWORDS

Assimilate: Whenever you play a non-neutral card that is not from your faction, boost it by the number of allied units with **Assimilate**. If there's an amount specified, count that unit that many times.

Banish: Remove a card from the Battlefield and put it in the unused cards. If an effect allows you to Spawn, Play etc. an unused cards, you may target a previously Banished card.

Charge (X): A card with this keyword can hold multiple Order tokens. When played, put X exhausted Order tokens on the card instead of 1 (as defined by the **Order** keyword). Some effects may give **Charges** to cards – this means putting the specified number of ready Order tokens on a card. The target of such effect must have the **Charge** keyword.

Important: if a card were to receive Charges on the same turn it was played, it receives exhausted Order tokens instead.

Conspiracy: Triggers an effect if the target of this cards ability has the Spying status.

Consume: Destroy an allied unit and boost self by its power.

Cooldown X: When this card performs an **Order**, place X Cooldown tokens on it. At the end of your turn, remove 1 Cooldown token from every card you control. If you remove the last Cooldown token from a card, refresh its **Order**.

Crew: Triggers an effect if both of the cards adjacent to this one are Soldiers.

Deathblow: Triggers an additional effect if this cards damage killed another unit.

Deathwish: Trigger this ability when destroyed and moved from the battlefield to the graveyard.

Defender, Shield, Veil, Doomed, Resilience: When this card is played or **Summoned**, gain the specified status.

Deploy: Triggers an ability when a card is played. Summoning a card does not trigger **Deploy**.

Disloyal: This card is played on the opposite side of the battlefield. Upon playing, it gains the Spying status.

Dominance: Trigger this ability if you control the highest unit on the battlefield. If there's a tie, both players have **Dominance**.

Echo: On round end, if this card is in the graveyard, put it on top of that players deck. When this card is played for the second time in a match, remove it from the game.

Focus Charge: When you perform the action of the card, remove half the charges from your Arcane Circle (rounded up). Focus Charge is equal to the number of the charges removed.

Focus: If you do not control an Arcane Circle, immediately summon one. At the end of your turn, place one Charge token on the Arcane Circle for every unit with Focus you control. If a unit has a Focus value specified, count it that many times. If a unit has an **Order** ability, only count it if the Order is not used.

Formation: If this card is played in the Melee row, gain **Zeal**. If this card is played in the Ranged row, boost self by 1.

Frost: Spawn a Frost card and summon it to the enemy row. Place the specified number of charges on it.

Inspired: Triggers an effect if the unit is boosted.

Lock: Give a unit the Lock status.

Melee: Only triggers an ability when a card is played in the Melee row. Can be a part of a passive ability (**Melee:**), a **Deploy (Melee:**) or an **Order (Order (Melee:))**.

Order: When a card with an **Order** is played or Summoned, place an exhausted Order token on it. At the end of a players turn the Order becomes ready.

Poison: Give a unit the Poison status.

Purify: Remove all statuses from a unit.

Ranged: Similar to **Melee**, but refers to the Ranged row.

Resupply: Triggers an effect every time you play a Warfare card.

Seize: Move an enemy unit to the opposite row on your side of the battlefield. Give it the Spying status.

Spawn: Take the specified card from the Token deck and **Summon** it to an allied row. If there are no more such cards in the Token deck, nothing happens.

Summon: Place a card in the rightmost space of a row. It does not trigger the **Deploy** ability.

The Order ability can be triggered manually by the player if the card has a ready Order token. On your turn, discard that token and perform the ability.

Thrive: Boost this unit by 1 whenever you play a unit with higher power.

Zeal: All Order tokens on this card are always on the ready side. This means that a player can use this cards **Order** on the same turn it was played.

FAQ AND RULE CLARIFICATIONS

Abilities – Can you skip part of a cards ability?

No, once triggered, a cards ability must be performed, even if it is detrimental to the player.

Allied unit – What is considered an allied unit?

Every unit on your side of the battlefield, including Disloyal units that your opponent played.

Bribery – How exactly does it work?

Bribery can at first sound confusing, but it is actually quite simple. It allows you to look at the top 3 cards of your opponents deck and swap one of those cards with a card from your hand. The cards **must** be of the same border color – if you have no card of the same border color as any of the 3 cards, you may not perform a swap.

After the swap, shuffle the 2 cards that weren't chosen and the swapped card from hand, and put them back on top of opponents deck. Now you may play an additional card from hand, and then draw a card. You can play the swapped card now or save it for later.

Defender – What if there are two cards with Defender on the same row?

Then the opponent may target either of the Defender cards, but may not target any card without the Defender status on that row.

Doomed – What happens when a card with doomed is the target of cards like Coup de Gras or Yennefer Invocation?

Doomed states that when a card is removed from the battlefield, it is removed from the game. Yennefer Invocation places a unit into the deck, removing it from battlefield and thus Banishing it – the card is removed from the board and not put into the deck.

However, Coup de Grace immediately replays the destroyed card, meaning it does not leave the battlefield – even a Doomed card can be replayed.

Enemy unit – What is considered an enemy unit?

Every unit on opponent's side of the battlefield, including Disloyal units that you played.

Full row – What happens if a row becomes full?

Each row can only contain 7 cards. If a row is full, no more cards can be played in that row. If both rows on a players side of the battlefield are full, they may not play any units (except for units with Disloyal, provided there is space on the other side of the battlefield). Special cards can still be played normally.

If a card effect forces a player to play a unit, but there is no space for it, the unit is immediately discarded.

If a card is Summoned to a full row, it is discarded. If it is a Token, remove it from the game instead.

Lock – Does locking a card disable its name or tags?

No, a card keeps its name and tags even if it is locked. For example, if an ability referred to the number of Soldiers the player controls, a locked Soldier unit will still count.

No viable card – What if an ability has you play, Summon etc. a specific card, but no viable card exists?

Nothing happens. For example, if your opponent has no more cards left in their deck and an ability has them play the top card of their deck, the ability will do nothing.

Playing cards – When a card effect makes you play a card, can you discard it instead?

No. Some cards, such as Cantarella or Oneiromancy, allow you to play more cards. This **must** be performed – a player has to play the target card, they may not discard it. Sometimes a player will be unlucky and playing a card may be detrimental to them, however it still may not be skipped.

Purify – What is and what is not removed from a card when it is purified?

Purification only removes the statuses (See page Statuses10), it has no effect on other tokens placed on the card. It will not affect a units power, Order tokens, the Imposter token etc.

Reset – How to reset a units order?

This means give an Order token to a unit with an Order ability, but no Order token. This includes units with a Charge keyword but no Charges.

Reset – How to reset a units power?

Remove all boost and damage from a unit.

Reset – How to reset a unit?

Remove all boost, damage, and statuses from a unit. If it has an Order ability, remove all Order tokens from it, then give it an Order token.

Then – How does the word “then” work in abilities?

The word “then” defines the order in which actions should be performed. If the first action cannot be performed, the second action won’t be performed.

For example, if a card allows you to “play a Bronze card, then draw a card”, if you do not have a Bronze card then you cannot perform the ability. No card was played, so no card will be drawn.

Unused – Which cards are “unused”?

Every card, excluding the ones drafted into players decks and the Tokens, is considered unused. When a card is Banished, add it to the unused cards – it may technically enter the match again.

Veil – What if a unit with a status receives Veil?

The unit keeps all its past statuses and Veil. No more statuses may be applied to this unit. This means that if a unit with Poison and Veil were to be Poisoned, it will survive.